BANGLADESH



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THE CHALLENGES AHEAD FOR HASINA

most vocal and had blacklisted senior officials of the anti-terrorist organisation, the Rapid Action Battalion. It had also announced that visas would be denied to anyone indulging in malpractices in the election process. The American ambassador in Dhaka was in an overdrive to mobilise opposition parties and anti-government NGOs to mount pressure on the PM. But these tactics failed in the face of a steadfast Hasina and the BNP boycott.

China and Russia publicly opposed this American interference. India, too, conveyed its objections to Washington privately. It has been speculated that American pressure was mounted to warn Hasina to not get too close to China. The US was also keen for Bangladesh to come on board its Indo-Pacific strategy and sign military cooperation agreements. Bangladesh has been reluctant to join any camp and has balanced its ties with all countries, particularly India and China, following Beijing's strategic foray into India's neighbourhood with its BRI (Belt and Road Initiative) and generous loans that have left countries like Maldives and Sri Lanka in deep debt.

Hasina has been accused of authoritarian behaviour and has clamped down on dissent in her previous terms as PM. She has, however, guided Bangladesh towards unprecedented economic growth. Bangladesh was the fastest growing Asian economy in the pre-Covid era. Its GDP, exports, foreign exchange reserves and per capita GDP today exceed those of Pakistan. Ties with India are robust; Bangladesh is India's largest trading partner in the subcontinent and recipient of over $10 billion in Indian development assistance. While the current economic downturn in Bangladesh has triggered inflation and caused a cost of living crisis among the disadvantaged, an economic recovery will be sustained in Hasina's new term.

FOR INDIA, HASINA ENSURES CONTINUITY IN THE UPGRADING OF BILATERAL TIES THAT CAN LEAD TO PROGRESS AND STABILITY IN THE EAST

There are several challenges ahead for Hasina, the economy being the primary one. The steady inroad made by Islamists have changed attitudes towards religion. There are more women in burkha and hijab now than when the country was East Pakistan. Madrasas have flourished, indoctrinating students who are ready fodder for extremism. Sporadic attacks on Hindus, loot of their properties, attacks on religious events and temples have not abated. Rarely are the perpetrators punished. Hasina's record on cracking down on violent Islamists has been commendable, but she has also made compromises with Islamist parties. In foreign affairs, Hasina will follow a policy of positive neutrality. Hence, we can expect a continuation of Bangladesh's policy of balancing ties with all major powers. Western markets are important for Bangladesh's exports of readymade garments. Despite the irritation caused by US pronouncements and visa sanctions, bilateral engagement will continue.

For India, Hasina ensures a continuity in the upgrading of bilateral ties, which can lead to economic progress, connectivity and stability in the eastern region. India has to deliver on Bangladesh's expectation on fair sharing of river waters, beginning with the Teesta. India should also facilitate more imports from Bangladesh to reduce the trade imbalance, address non-tariff barriers, ensure better border management, increase intelligence and security cooperation and cooperate on UN peacekeeping operations. India must continue its support for Bangladesh's food and energy security and people-centric development assistance and mitigate its vulnerability to climate change. The road ahead for bilateral ties is potentially promising as well as challenging. ■

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PREMIER AGAIN Sheikh Hasina at a press conference in Dhaka following her election victory, Jan. 8

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